

Comprehensive Lesson Plan: Four Directions Model

General Information

- **Title:** Trees as Our Teachers: Learning Through Two-Eyed Seeing
- **Grade Level:** Grade 2
- **Subject:** Integration of Science and Social Studies
- **Duration:** Three 45-minute lessons
- **Author:** Patricia Zapata Barrientos

Rationale & Pedagogical Framework

This unit introduces Grade 2 students to the concept of Two-Eyed Seeing (*Étuaptmumk*). Students learn to view the natural world through a holistic lens: using one eye to focus on Western scientific perspectives (observation of structures and life cycles) and the other eye to value Indigenous ways of knowing (relationality, reciprocity, and land-based storytelling).

By structuring the lessons around the Four Directions (NSEW) Model, learning becomes a cyclical journey that honors heart, mind, body, and spirit. This shift from learning *about* nature to learning *from* nature fosters authentic reconciliation and a sense of responsibility toward the local environment. As a teacher candidate implementing this framework, the focus is on co-learning alongside students, ensuring inclusive practices where every child—regardless of their learning style or needs—can safely access the land and share their voice.

BC Curriculum Connections

Big Ideas

- **Science 2:** Living things have life cycles adapted to their environment.
- **Social Studies 2:** Regional landscapes shape who we are and how we live.

Curricular Competencies

- **Experience and interpret the local environment:** Actively engage with the local land to observe relationships.
- **Observe objects and events in familiar contexts:** Use multiple senses to gather data about local trees.
- **Express feelings and views about a topic:** Communicate personal connections to the environment.
- **Compare observations with those of others:** Share and listen to peer perspectives to build shared understanding.

Content Elements

- **Living things in local environments:** Identifying local tree species and their basic needs.
- **Relationships between living things and their habitats:** Understanding how trees support biodiversity.
- **Indigenous knowledge of local environments:** Exploring how local First Nations interact with, honor, and utilize local trees (such as the Western Red Cedar).

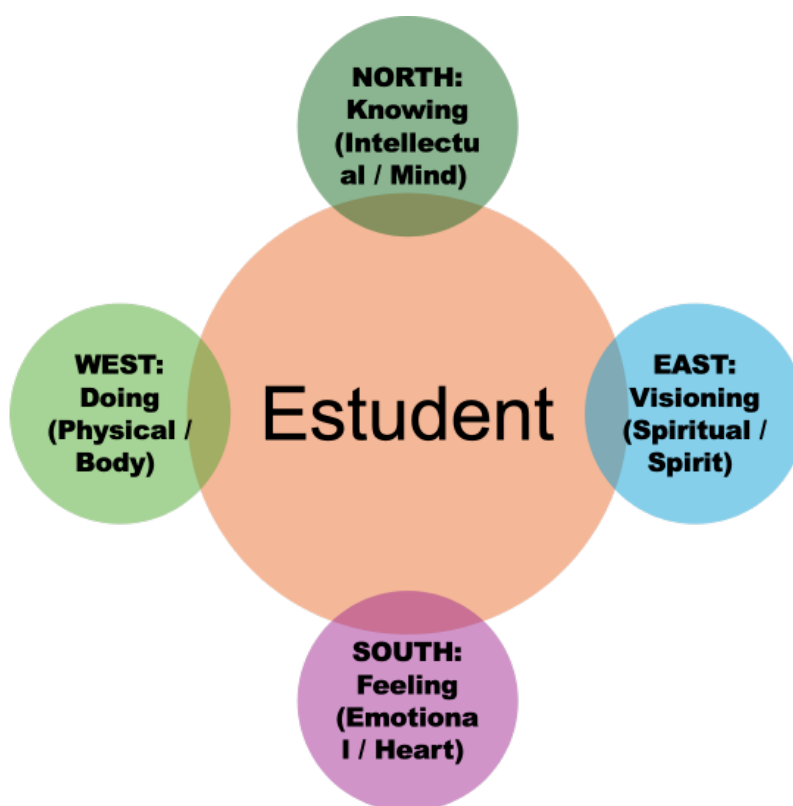
Holistic Integrating Themes: Truth, Justice, Reconciliation, and Two-Eyed Seeing

- **Truth:** Acknowledging that Indigenous peoples have held deep, scientific, and spiritual relationships with local ecosystems since time immemorial. The land is a network of relatives, not an empty space to exploit.
- **Justice:** Intentionally elevating Indigenous knowledge to the same level of academic validity as Western science in our classroom practices.
- **Reconciliation:** Cultivating a mindset of reciprocity. Students move beyond passive listening to active stewardship, taking responsibility for the well-being of the land we share.
- **Two-Eyed Seeing:** Actively guiding students to look at a tree and see both its biological functions (oxygen, roots) and its role as a living teacher and relative (community support, historical witness).

First Peoples Principles of Learning (FPPL)

- Learning is holistic, reflexive, reflective, experiential, and relational (focused on connectedness, on reciprocal relationships, and a sense of place).
- Learning ultimately supports the well-being of self, family, community, land, and the environment.

The Four Directions Learning Cycle (NSEW)



1. NORTH: Knowing (Intellectual / Mind) — Scientific Perspectives

- **Focus:** What do our eyes see? How are trees structured?
- **Activity:** Outdoor Circle & Botanical Observation.
- **Process:** We begin in the North, gathering students in an outdoor learning circle under a prominent local tree. Students use their observation journals to sketch the anatomy of

the tree (roots, trunk, bark, branches, leaves/needles). Back in the classroom, we integrate Western science terminology to discuss how roots stabilize soil and absorb water, and how leaves capture sunlight.

2. SOUTH: Feeling (Emotional / Heart) — Relational Perspectives

- **Focus:** How do we relate to trees? What stories do they tell?
- **Activity:** Storytelling and the Heart of the Forest.
- **Process:** Moving to the South, we engage the heart. The teacher reads *Shi-shi-etko* by Nicola Campbell. We connect this story to the concept of **connectedness** (interconnection): explaining how the land and trees hold memories and hold a deep familial value for Indigenous communities. Students reflect on how trees care for us and how nature keeps our memories safe.

3. EAST: Visioning (Spiritual / Spirit) — Imagining a Shared Future

- **Focus:** What do we hope for our forest relatives?
- **Activity:** Metaphorical Mapping / Creative Art.
- **Process:** In the East, the direction of vision, students reflect on the interdependence of the forest. They create an artistic rendering titled *"The Forest We Dream Of."* Using mixed media (crayons, oil pastels, and fallen leaves collected from the ground), they draw a healthy ecosystem where trees, animals, and humans thrive together, showing a future of mutual respect.

4. WEST: Doing (Physical / Body) — Active Stewardship

- **Focus:** What is our responsibility now?
- **Activity:** "Tree Care Promises" Dialogue Circles.
- **Process:** The cycle completes in the West with action. Students sit in a simplified *Talking Circle* format to share their physical commitment to the land. Each student designs a small paper leaf containing their "Tree Care Promise" (e.g., *"I promise to protect young seedlings on the trail"*). These promises represent concrete, relational actions and are attached to a classroom "Community Witness Tree" display.

Detailed Lesson Sequence

Lesson 1: Our Neighbors, the Trees (North Focus)

- **Objective:** Identify basic needs and physical structures of local trees through direct observation.
- **Introduction (10 mins):** Gather at the carpet. Introduce the term *Two-Eyed Seeing*. Explain that we will use our first eye to look like scientists today.
- **Core Activity (25 mins):** Head outside to the schoolyard green space. Distribute the Student Handout. Students choose one specific tree to observe closely, touch the bark, and complete Section 1 ("What I See / What I Wonder") of their handout.
- **Safety/Setting:** Ensure students remain within boundaries and treat the living trees with physical gentleness.
- **Differentiated Support (Outdoor Learning):** For students with mobility challenges, select an observation site with flat, accessible terrain near the paved schoolyard. For students who experience sensory overload or attentional difficulties outdoors, provide a specific, smaller boundary or pair them with a designated peer buddy. Offer alternative clipboards with built-in pencil holders and pre-weighted sensory seating pads if needed.
- **Closure (10 mins):** Return to the classroom. Share observations. Focus on what trees need to survive in this environment.

Lesson 2: Connectedness and Memories (South & East Focus)

- **Objective:** Recognize that trees are connected to our feelings, memories, and families, using both stories and science.
- **Introduction (10 mins):** Gather at the carpet. Read the book *Shi-shi-etko* by Nicola Campbell. Introduce the story with sensitivity, explaining that Shi-shi-etko gathers reminders of her land before leaving home.
- **Core Activity (25 mins):**
 - **Discussion:** Guide a sharing circle about how the land holds memories. Contrast a mechanical view of trees (just wood/oxygen) with a relational view (trees as family and keepers of history).

- **Art Activity:** Transition to the *Visioning* art project. Students begin drawing their healthy, interconnected forest, showing how animals and people benefit from healthy trees.
 - **In-Progress Formative Assessment (Checking for Understanding):** While students are actively engaged in the art project, the teacher will circulate with a clipboard to conduct "side-by-side" mini-conferences. Instead of waiting until the final submission at the end of the unit, the teacher will check conceptual comprehension in real time by asking scaffolding questions such as: *"Can you show me in your drawing where the trees are helping another forest relative (animal or human)?"* or *"How does your artwork show the connection and memories we talked about in Campbell's story?"*
- **Closure (10 mins):** Pair-share drawings. Students explain one way their drawing shows a healthy relationship with nature.

Lesson 3: Living Our Promises (West Focus)

- **Objective:** Formulate and share a personal action plan showing active stewardship for the environment.
- **Introduction (10 mins):** Review the concept of *Two-Eyed Seeing*. How do both science and stories tell us to treat trees? They both show that we need them to survive.
- **Core Activity (25 mins):** Introduce the "Tree Care Promise." Students finalize Section 3 of their handout and craft their promise on a paper leaf template. Hold a simplified *Talking Circle* where each student shares their promise aloud, practicing active listening and mutual respect.
- **Differentiated Support (Talking Circle):** To support English Language Learners (ELL) or students with speech anxiety during the oral sharing session, provide a visual sentence frame on a handheld card: *"I promise to care for the land by [action]."* Establish a physical *talking piece* (such as a smooth local stone or pinecone) to provide a grounding tactile focus. Explicitly teach and normalize the option to "pass" or use a non-verbal gesture (such as pointing to their written leaf template) to ensure a safe, inclusive, and low-stakes environment.
- **Closure (10 mins):** Attach the leaves to the classroom "Community Witness Tree" mural. Reflect on how our small actions support the broader community and land.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Trees as Our Teachers: My Learning Journey

My

goals
today:

☐

I can use my senses to observe a local tree.

☐

I can practice Two-Eyed Seeing (valuing science and stories together).

☐

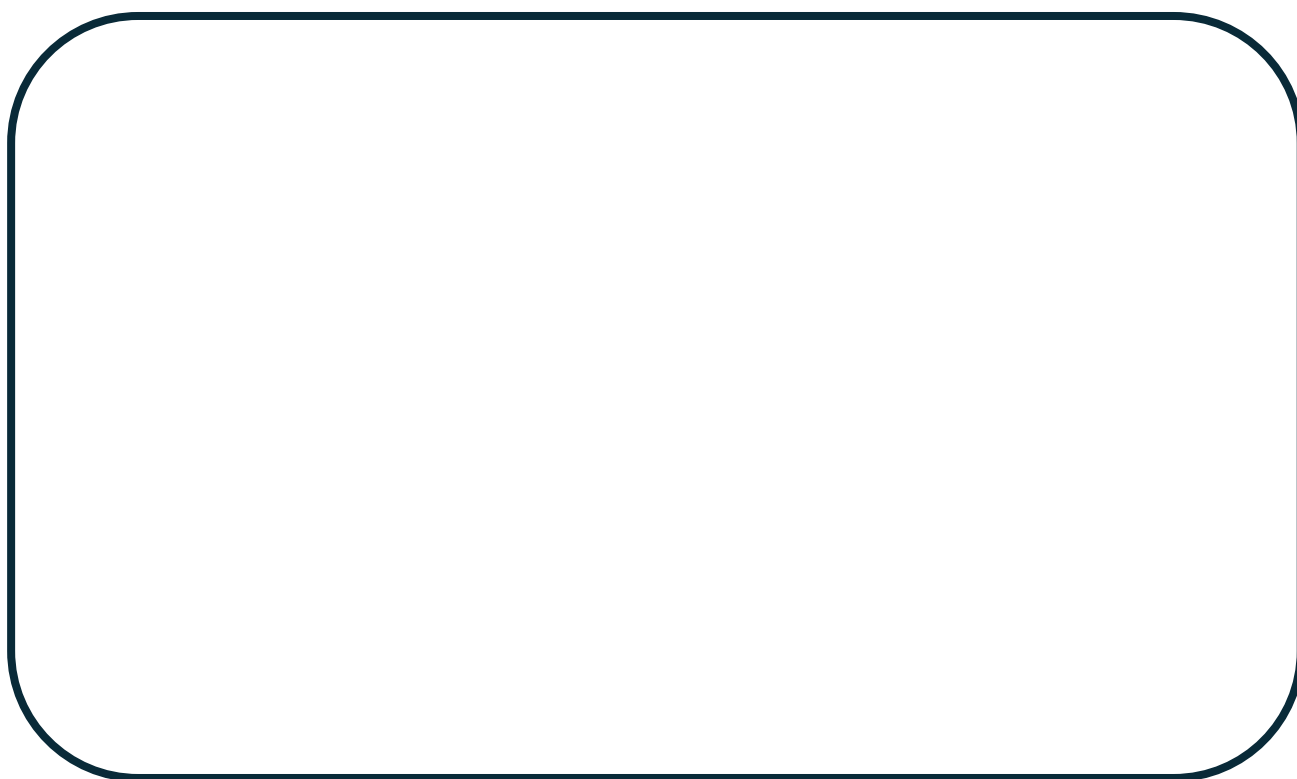
I can explain why trees are important to humans and animals.

☐

I can make a promise to care for our land.

1. *My Field Observations* (The North Eye)

Find a tree outside and look closely. Draw the tree in the box below.



What I See: _____.

What I Wonder: _____.

2. **Connectedness** (The South & East Heart)

How does the tree make me feel? What did Shi-shi-etko teach us about memories?

Trees provide a home for: _____

Nature makes me feel:



My drawing of a happy, healthy forest:

A large, empty rounded rectangle with a dark blue border, intended for a drawing of a happy, healthy forest.

3. **My Action (The West Hand)**

One big thing I learned from our tree teachers : _____

My Tree Care Promise:

A large, light green scroll-like box with a dark blue border. It has a scroll edge on the left and a small circular tab on the right. The text "I promise to care for the land by" is written at the top left of the box.

I promise to care for the land by

Assessment Tool: Holistic Framework Rubric

Criteria	Emerging	Developing	Proficient	Extending
Scientific Observation (North)	Observations are minimal or require constant teacher prompting to identify basic structures.	Identifies basic tree structures (leaves, trunk) with assistance; sketches lack detail.	Accurately observes and documents tree structures; asks relevant questions about needs.	Demonstrates exceptional attention to detail; notices subtle environmental interactions.
Relational Awareness (South/East)	Struggles to see trees beyond their functional utility for humans.	Expresses an initial understanding that trees have value, but struggles to articulate stories.	Clearly recognizes trees as interconnected living entities that support community well-being.	Articulates deep insights regarding interdependence, referencing Indigenous perspectives naturally.
Stewardship Action (West)	Requires heavy guidance to identify any basic environmental action.	Identifies a generic action (e.g., "don't litter") without direct connection to trees.	Formulates a personal, realistic "Tree Care Promise" reflecting local responsibility.	Proposes a thoughtful, creative action plan showing deep accountability to the local land.
Circle Engagement (Relationality)	Frequently distracted during storytelling or peer sharing circles.	Listens periodically; participates in sharing only when directly prompted by the teacher.	Practices active listening; respects the talking piece/circle protocol; shares authentically.	Models deep respect for peer voices; explicitly connects their reflections to others' ideas.

References (APA 7th Edition)

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- Bartlett, C., Marshall, M., & Marshall, A. (2012). Two-Eyed Seeing and other lessons learned within a co-learning journey of bringing together Indigenous and mainstream knowledges and ways of knowing. *Journal of Environmental Studies and Sciences*, 2(4), 331–340. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13412-012-0086-8>
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- Popp, J. (2018). Ways of knowing: Integrating Indigenous perspectives into the science classroom through Two-Eyed Seeing. *Science Scope*, 42(4), 22–27.